

SaveTheHives — “Genetic Goldmine” Language Check

For David Tarpy — revised Jul 21, 2026 · savethehives.org

This is a revised pass at the language I want to put on the project's Facebook page and eventually in press outreach — tightened up since our last conversation to be more careful about what's actually proven versus plausible. I'd still love your read as the person who knows this science: does this hold up, and where would you push back? A few words or a mark on the page is plenty.

THE CORE LANGUAGE (revised)

“Scattered across forests, old barns, and hollow trees are feral honey bee colonies that survive winter after winter with no mite treatments and no human management. A colony that persists three or more seasons on its own isn't just lucky — it's come through real, sustained natural selection from Varroa mites and the viruses they spread. That persistence may come from heritable resistance, from behavior, or from favorable local ecology — and untangling which one is exactly the kind of question that needs living colonies to study. That's why SaveTheHives calls these long-lived feral colonies Genetic Goldmines: not because the genetics are proven, but because each one is a real candidate for understanding how honey bees might survive without constant chemical support.”

QUESTIONS FOR YOU

1. The term itself

Is “Genetic Goldmine” framing you'd be comfortable seeing attached to this science, or is there language a researcher would trust more?

2. The causal hedge

Does attributing persistence to “heritable resistance, behavior, or favorable local ecology — and untangling which one needs living colonies to study” correctly represent the uncertainty, or would you word that differently?

3. The survival threshold

Is “three or more seasons, no treatment” a defensible bar for calling a colony notable, or would you set it differently?

4. The loss-rate stat (used elsewhere in the project's materials, not in this paragraph)

I cite a general, widely-used 30–50% annual managed-colony loss figure (industry-wide, not SaveTheHives data) in other posts. Comfortable with that range, or is there a better number/source you'd point me to?

5. Credit

Comfortable being named as a scientific advisor on this framing, or would you rather stay unattributed for now?

WHERE THIS LANGUAGE SHOWS UP

The SaveTheHives Facebook page (live now, first posts going out this week), the project's internal mission-explainer doc, and eventually the app's About panel and any press outreach — so whatever we land on today will likely stay consistent everywhere going forward.

Thanks again for taking the time on this — no rush, happy to talk it through over lunch or you can just mark this page up. — Ronnie · ronniebouchon@gmail.com